now trying to garner support of the SC/ST communities for whom the delimitation panel has reserved nine and seven seats, respectively. "This is political engineering at work to marginalise Kashmir," says former political science professor Noor Baba. "The BJP's plan is to weaken traditional political parties. The Pandits have suffered and they need to be reintegrated but this back door option is not the right way to do it."

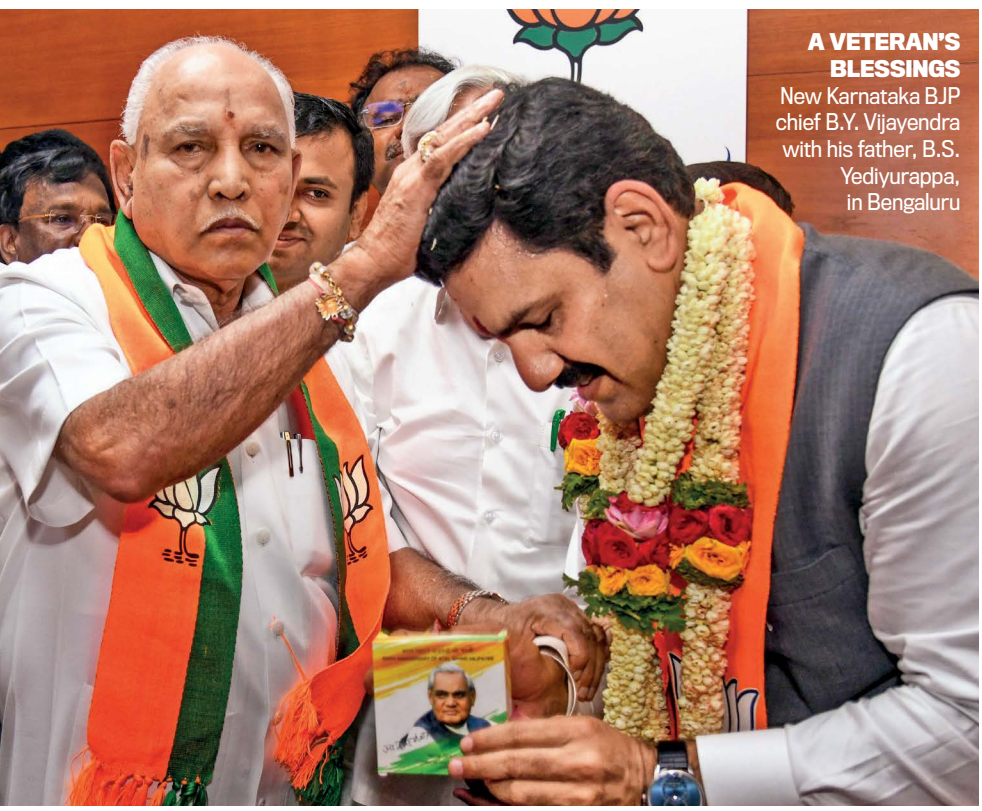
In fact, CPI(M) leader and ex-legislator Mohammed Tarigami suggests another solution instead of the "underhand" nomination route—the delimitation panel could have reserved some constituencies with sizeable populations of Kashmiri Pandits and PoJK refugees for candidates from the communities, just as they do for SC/STs. "Under the garb of favouring the Pandits, the Centre now wants to push their own man and further the party's interests. It is not empowerment if the community does not participate in nominating their representative," he says.

THE J&K OPPOSITION FEELS IT'S ALL PART OF THE BJP'S "BIGGER PLAN" TO HAVE A GOVERNMENT OF ITS OWN

Former CM Omar Abdullah says his party is not against reservation but, again, feels the move is solely aimed at helping the BJP gain numbers. "We are not against reservations...we have given reservations to women and others before. But reserving seats should be left to the elected state government and not those who have come after being nominated by the Government of India," says the NC vice-president. That is one side of the story, the Pandit community's travails are another. Whether the ruling BJP's designs are kosher or not is the third angle to it all. Whatever be the case, assuring the people's rights and an elected government at the earliest must be the top priority. ■

KARNATAKA

BJP REVAMPS TEAM K



A VETERAN'S BLESSINGS New Karnataka BJP chief B.Y. Vijayendra with his father, B.S. Yediyurappa, in Bengaluru

ANI

By Ajay Sukumaran

For six months after its drubbing in the May 2023 assembly polls, the BJP party unit in Karnataka remained in a sort of limbo. As the main Opposition party, its leaders were vocal in their criticism of the ruling Congress, but two nagging issues remained to be resolved: the party hadn't yet named its Leader of Opposition (LoP) in the assembly, nor had it chosen a successor to state party president Nalin Kumar Kateel, whose one-year extension of term in August 2022 trailed off into a hazy lame-duck status with the electoral defeat. In fact, the assembly session in July had witnessed the rare scene of the LoP's designated seat lying vacant during the debates.

That changed suddenly in mid-November, with the party